The role of Buddhist networks, and monks in particular, in defining 'the political' and influencing public opinion was a recurring concern for local political party campaign strategists in the months preceding Myanmar's 2015 elections. In Taungoo, the USDP publicly patronized Buddhism throughout Buddhist lent in August and September by hosting a series of robe-giving and donation celebrations. While such events were certainly public performances of the ongoing patronage the party and regime has provided Buddhism (see Schober 2011), USDP officials also emphasized the importance of maintaining good relations with monks to ensure the party retains its reputation of spiritual merit. Fears about the role of monks in influencing followers to support the USDP were voiced at an NLD strategy meeting prior to the commencement of formal campaigning in September 2015. Concerns were raised that a senior abbot in a village on the fringe of the township, who allegedly influenced villagers to support the USDP during the 2010 elections and 2012 by-elections, might urge his followers not to support the NLD again in 2015. While township party operatives urged local party members to continue their campaign and "take the chance … for the first time" to engage directly with individual voters, senior village members responded exasperatedly: "The Sayadaw has a lot of influence … Much more than us!" One candidate subsequently agreed to meet with the abbott and "get him to be a friend" — but also admitted his key objective would be to convince the abbott "not to deny the followers the chance to participate in the election". Such anxieties, and the need for overt strategies to manage religious actors, highlight the sacred position monks and religious institutions play as central nodes of both ritual and social action, creating relationships through which the scope of 'politics' is often (re)defined for everyday people.[11]

'UNDECIDEDS' AND THE CENTRALITY OF BUDDHIST INSTITUTIONS

The 'depoliticizing' legacies of authoritarianism, the effects of recent national-level reforms, and the notions of meritorious social action and moral crisis popularized by Buddhist networks of ritual and welfare have created a context where many citizens are unsure how to define 'politics' and reach decisions about who to support.

A Shan family in a rural village around twenty minutes outside